



Participant Information and Consent Form

Title	Library digital accessibility for neurodivergent students
Principal Investigator	Sandy Houston, Senior User Experience Designer, RMIT University Library
Associate Investigator	Kelly Ann Smith, Specialist Digital Learning Resources, RMIT University Library

What does my participation involve?

1 Introduction

You are invited to take part in this research project, which is called **Library digital accessibility for neurodivergent students**. You expressed interest to participate in the study by completing the expression of interest form for the study.

This Participant Information and Consent Form informs you about the research project. It explains the processes involved with taking part. Knowing what is involved will help you decide if you want to take part in the research.

Please read this information carefully. Ask questions about anything that you don't understand or want to know more about. You can contact the researcher at sandy.houston@rmit.edu.au. Before deciding whether to take part, you might want to talk about it with a relative or friend.

Participation in this research is voluntary. If you don't wish to take part, you don't have to.

If you decide you want to take part in the research project, you will be asked to confirm your consent in the online expression of interest form and again verbally at the start of the session. By giving your consent, you are telling us that you:

- Understand what you have read
- Consent to take part in the research project

You can save or print a copy of this Participant Information and Consent Form to keep.

At the start of your session, the researcher will briefly explain the study again and ask you to describe, in your own words, what the session involves and that you can stop at any time. This is to make sure the project is clear and that you feel comfortable taking part.

2 What is the purpose of this research?

This project aims to make RMIT Library's digital resources more accessible for neurodivergent students. We invite you to test and provide feedback on the usability of selected Library websites, online tools and prototypes. These insights will help the Library make changes so that students can access information and resources more easily and confidently.

This research has been funded by the RMIT Inclusive Education Innovation Grant Program. The researchers are staff members of RMIT Library. Your honest feedback, including criticism of Library tools and services, is very important and will not affect your access to Library services or your studies.

3 What does participation in this research involve?

We are working on a prototype website that specifically supports learning experiences for neurodivergent students.

You will join a 1-hour online Microsoft Teams call with a member of the research team (and possibly a note taker). The session has two parts:

1. **Short interview** – We will ask you some open-ended questions about your experiences as a student, your accessibility needs, and your use of Library or study tools. You can choose how much detail you share.
2. **Usability session** – You will be invited to share your screen and complete some tasks using the prototype website and possibly other Library tools (for example, Learning Lab or Assignment Planner). You will be encouraged to “think aloud” and tell us what you are doing and how it feels as you go.

There are no right or wrong answers. Any difficulties you encounter are about the design of the tools, not about you as a user.

With your consent, the session will be recorded using Microsoft Teams. The recording helps us check our notes and create a transcript so we can accurately capture your feedback. You may choose to have your camera off if you prefer; however, we will ask you to share your screen so we can see how you use the websites.

You will be offered the option to review the interview part of your transcript and ask for any corrections or for sections to be removed within 2 weeks of receiving it. If we do not hear from you within 2 weeks, we will assume the transcript is accepted as recorded and will use your interview data in our analysis.

You may choose not to review your transcript. You can also change your mind and request to review it at any time within the 2-week review period.

You will be reimbursed for your time with a digital gift card for Myer to the value of **\$50**. The gift card will be sent to you via your RMIT student email after you complete the session.

4 Other relevant information about the research project

The research will involve two rounds of testing. Each round will include around 12 participants, made up of both undergraduate and postgraduate RMIT students who self-identify as neurodivergent. A different group of students will take part in each round.

Round 1 will focus on testing the initial prototype and identifying usability and accessibility issues. Based on these findings, we will refine the design and content. Round 2 will then involve a new group of students testing the revised prototype to see whether these changes have improved accessibility and to identify any remaining issues.

5 Do I have to take part in this research project?

Participation in any research project is voluntary. If you do not wish to take part, you do not have to. If you decide to take part and later change your mind, you are free to withdraw from the project at any stage. Your decision whether to take part or not to take part, or to take part and then withdraw, will not affect your relationship with the researchers or with RMIT University.

You may stop the interview at any time. If you withdraw during or immediately after the session, any recordings will be deleted and information you have provided will not be included in the study results. You may also refuse to answer any questions that you do not wish to answer during the interview or usability session.

6 What are the possible benefits of taking part?

While you may not receive any direct personal benefit, your involvement will help the Library enhance digital resources for the neurodivergent community. Your participation may also contribute to improving products and strategies intended for all users.

7 What are the risks and disadvantages of taking part?

If you find a question stressful or upsetting, you may skip it and go to the next question, or you may stop immediately. In the unlikely event that you become upset or distressed because of your participation in the research project, members of the research team will be able to discuss appropriate support for you. If you become distressed and would like further support, we can provide you with information about RMIT support services such as Equitable Learning Services and Counselling and Psychological Services (CAPS).

If at any point you experience any emotional distress, you can reach out to RMIT University Counselling and Psychological Services by booking an online appointment [link to booking portal] or by calling Student Connect on +61 3 9925 5000 and selecting the option for "Counselling" (Student Connect phonenumber operating hours: 9am-5pm Mon-Thu, 10am-5pm Fri, excluding public holidays)

8 What if I withdraw from this research project?

If you do consent to participate, you may withdraw at any time. If you decide to withdraw from the project, please notify a member of the research team. If you withdraw during or immediately after the session, any recordings will be deleted and information you have provided will not be included in the study results. After the data have been de-identified and combined with other participants' data, it may not be possible to remove your individual contribution, but we will do our best to accommodate withdrawal requests wherever practicable.

9 What happens when the research project ends?

A report will be written that summarizes what we learned from participants and how we plan to use their feedback to improve Library products and services. You can let us know if you would like to receive a copy of this report.

How is the research project being conducted?

10 What will happen to information about me?

By signing the consent form, you consent to the research team collecting and using information from you for the research project. Any information obtained in connection with this research project that can identify you will remain confidential. Recordings of your session will be stored securely on RMIT systems and used only to create and check transcripts and notes. Once accurate, de-identified transcripts have been created and checked, the original recordings will be securely deleted.

Data will be de-identified and stored securely. Access is restricted to the Digital Learning Team in RMIT Library. Results will be published without personal identification.

It is anticipated that the results of this research project will be published and/or presented in a variety of forums. Research findings may be shared through reports or presentations. Information will be shared in ways that protect your privacy. For example, instead of names, participants will be referred to as "Participant 1, Participant 2" etc.

11 Who is organising and funding the research?

This research project is being conducted by Sandy Houston of RMIT Library with funding from the RMIT Inclusive Education Innovation Grant Program.

12 Who has reviewed the research project?

All research in Australia involving humans is reviewed by an independent Ethics review body. This research project has been approved by one of the RMIT University review bodies. This project will be carried out according to the *National Statement on Ethical Conduct in Human Research* (2023). This statement has been developed to protect the interests of people who agree to participate in human research studies.

13 Further information and who to contact

If you want any further information concerning this project, you can contact the researcher at sandy.houston@rmit.edu.au.

Research contact person

Name	Sandy Houston
Position	Senior User Experience Designer, RMIT Library
Email	sandy.houston@rmit.edu.au

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14 Complaints

Should you have any concerns or questions about this research project, which you do not wish to discuss with the researchers listed in this document, then you may contact:

Reviewing HREC name	RMIT University
HREC Secretary	Pascal Bernard
Telephone	03 9925 1985
Email	humanethics@rmit.edu.au
Mailing address	Manager, Research Governance and Ethics RMIT University GPO Box 2476 MELBOURNE VIC 3001

Acknowledgement by Participant – by submitting the online form and attending the session:

I have read and understood the Participant Information Sheet.

I understand the purposes, procedures and risks of the research described in the project.

I have had an opportunity to ask questions and I am satisfied with the answers I have received.

I freely agree to participate in this research project as described and understand that I am free to withdraw at any time during the project without affecting my relationship with RMIT.

I understand that I can print or download a copy of this document to keep.

By submitting the online expression of interest form after reading this information sheet, and by attending the session, I indicate my consent to participate in this study.